

Puberty problems

The average age for puberty to start in males is 12 years old, although it can be anytime between the ages of 9 and 14. If puberty starts before 9 years old, it is called “precocious puberty.” If this occurs, it’s best to see a doctor to find out why the body has triggered puberty early. It may lead to an early growth spurt that then also stops sooner than it should, leaving a person shorter than average as an adult. Similarly, if puberty occurs much later than 14 years of age, with no testicular development, medical advice should be sought.

GOOD TO KNOW

Gynecomastia

Gynecomastia, otherwise known as “man boobs” or “moobs,” may be caused by changing hormone levels, which can make a male’s “breasts” swell. This is a common, temporary occurrence that usually resolves itself between six months and two years. However, if the swelling persists or there are any asymmetrical changes in breast size, or lumps or bumps on the chest, see a doctor.



Growth spurts

Between the ages of 12 and 15 years, males grow an average of 3–3.5 in (7–9 cm) per year, with periods of rapid growth affecting different parts of the body at different times. The hands and feet usually grow first, followed by the arms and legs, with the spine and torso growing last.

These differently timed growth rates can often cause clumsiness in teens, as the muscles needed to keep them balanced play catch-up, and the part of the brain that deals with spatial awareness takes time to adjust to the individual’s new body proportions.

Building body confidence

Feeling confident on the inside makes a big difference when a teen is dealing with the many changes taking place outside the body. The important thing is not to worry about what is happening to other people, as everyone matures differently.



△ Focus on the positives

Think about the incredible things the body can do, such as dance, run, and sing.

TEEN HINTS

Embracing change

- Your body lets you participate in exciting activities—focus on what it can do, rather than how it looks.
- Speak to yourself positively. Give yourself compliments as a friend would, and avoid putting yourself down.
- Choose clothes that make you feel good, and focus on the parts of your body you like best.

PARENT TIPS

Supporting your teen

- Try to make this exciting life stage feel positive, to build your teen’s self-esteem about who they are becoming.
- Providing your teen with all the information and practical stuff they might need can help them feel better prepared to manage the physical changes when they happen.
- If you’re embarrassed about broaching these topics, acknowledge it to your teen—it will help your teen to see that being honest about their body is healthy.